both introspection and more transparency. We can have differing interpretations of facts, of course, but only if the data itself is correct. When institutions that are the touchstones of academic credibility produce misleading data, it skews our basic understanding of society and erodes public trust. We hope the findings of the Mehta–Singh Index will start a much-needed debate.

In terms of the wider political terrain, these changes on caste-representation by the BJP came on the back of ten years of successive rule in UP by the state's regional caste-based parties: first the BSP (2007–2012) and then the SP (2012–2017). Unlike in the 1990s, these parties were no longer challengers or rebels with a cause but an integral part of the power structure. In tandem with the BJP's expansion, both parties saw a contraction of their voter base even while they were in power, while the Congress sank into insignificance. At the same time, the Modi period has also seen in UP a solidification and retrieval of savarns who had drifted away from the party in the early 2000s. However, upper-caste mobilisation is not the story of this phase of Indian politics, as this chapter has demonstrated. The expansion of the BJP's vote base, its new MPs, MLAs and office-bearers has been tilted in favour of OBCs in the new BJP. They made up exactly half of its MPs elected from general-category seats nationwide. Within UP, OBCs (mostly non-Yadav) constituted over one-third of the party's Lok Sabha candidates and ministers in Yogi Adityanath's government, and almost one-third of its Vidhan Sabha candidates, state-level officer-bearers and district presidents. Similarly, the BJP significantly upped SC (mostly non-Jatav) representation among its MPs, MLAs, state-level office-bearers and ministers. So much so that OBCs and SCs, taken together, came to occupy half or more than half of the leadership positions at virtually every level of the party, barring its district presidents.

This Mandalisation of the BJP—caste mobilisation without caste wars or confrontations[62]—brought the party's composition closer to the overall population composition of UP than any of its rivals had managed. The unprecedented inclusion of these castes in the party's power structures, combined with an unprecedented cadre expansion, especially with those under forty-five years of age,